Where the Money Actually Is

Buy, Build & Bet decisions from 1,000 micro-SaaS startups

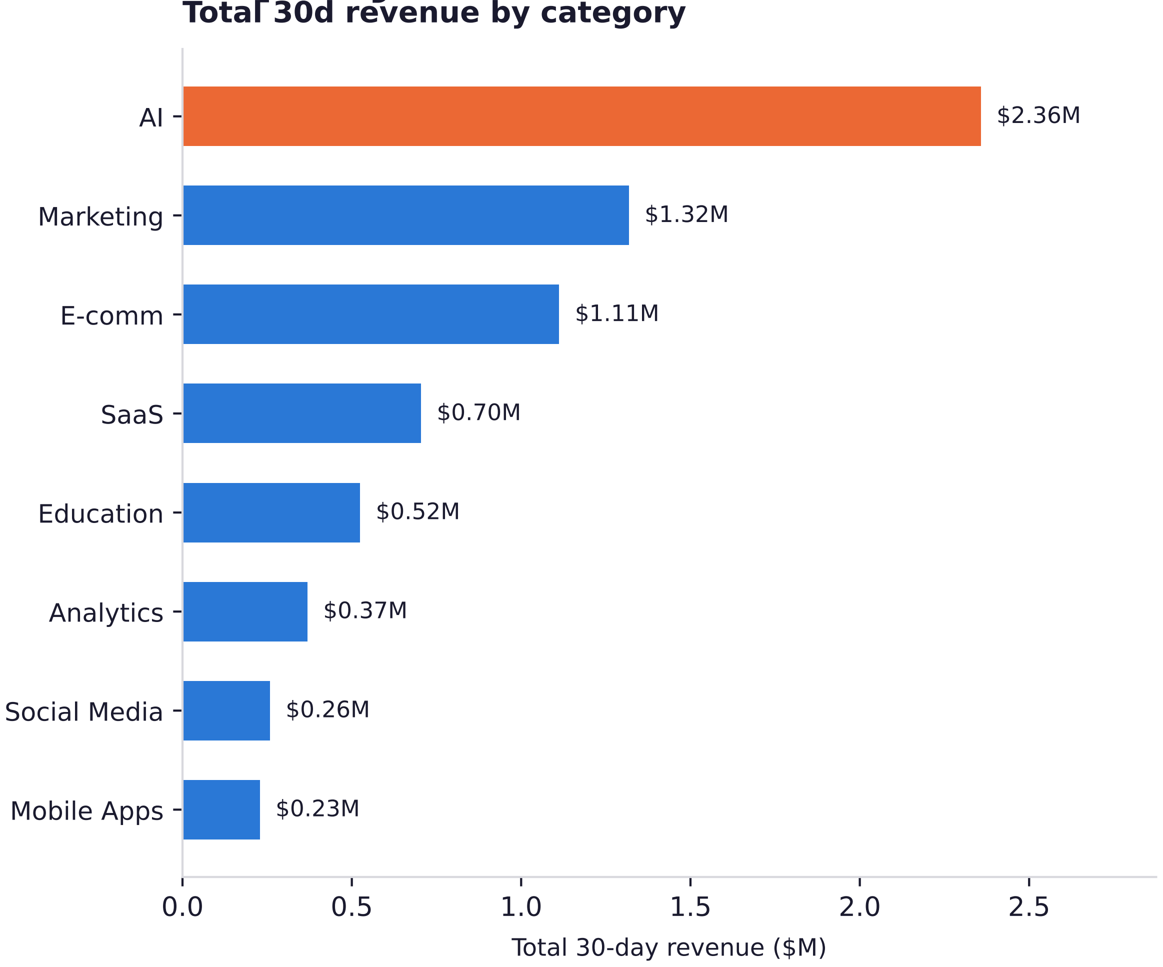
9 decision-grade insights · category economics · acquisition targets

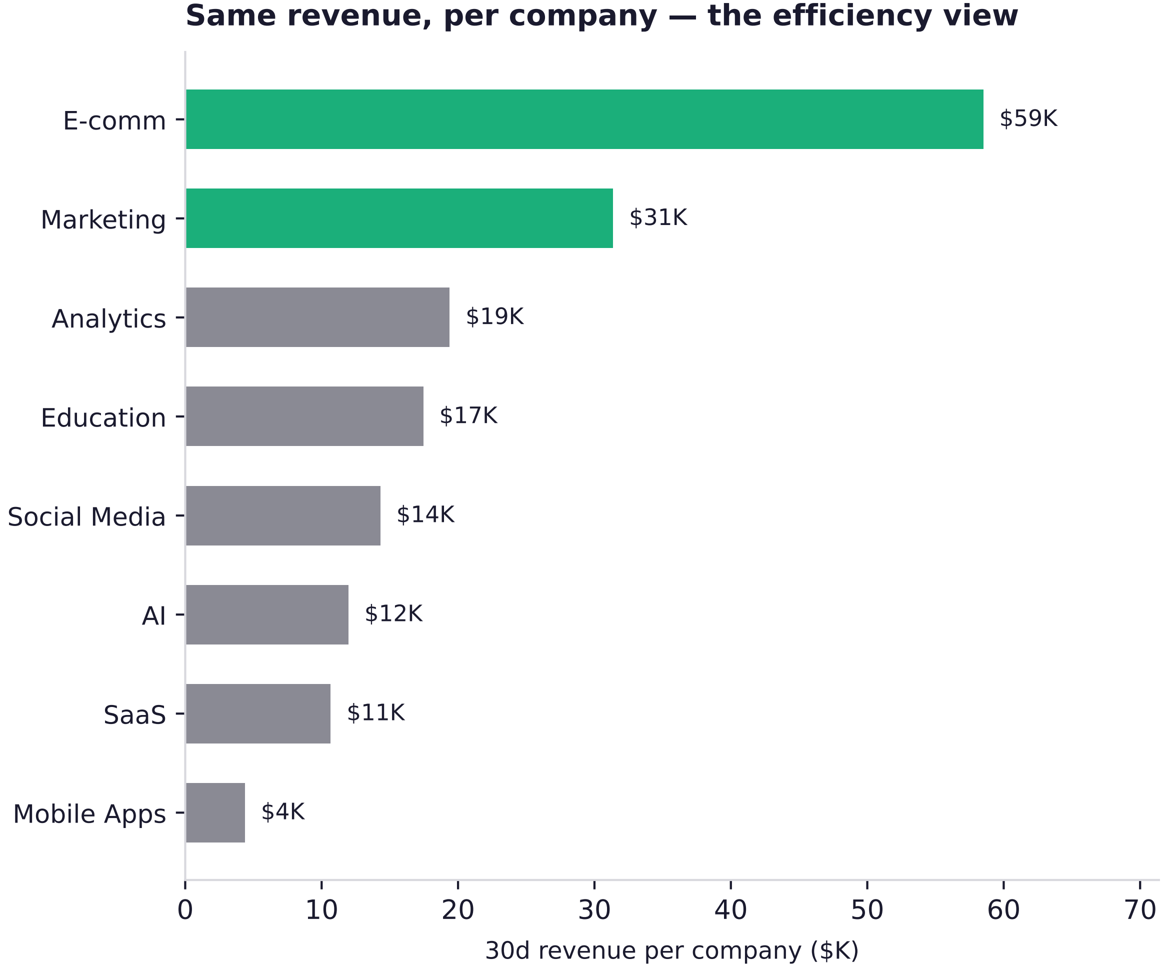
growth signals · correlation evidence · payment-rail intelligence

TrustMRR dataset · 1,000 rows · frozen 30 Jul 2026 · Masters Union Session 3

INSIGHT 1 · REVENUE ENGINES

AI prints the most cash — but Marketing & E-comm out-earn per company

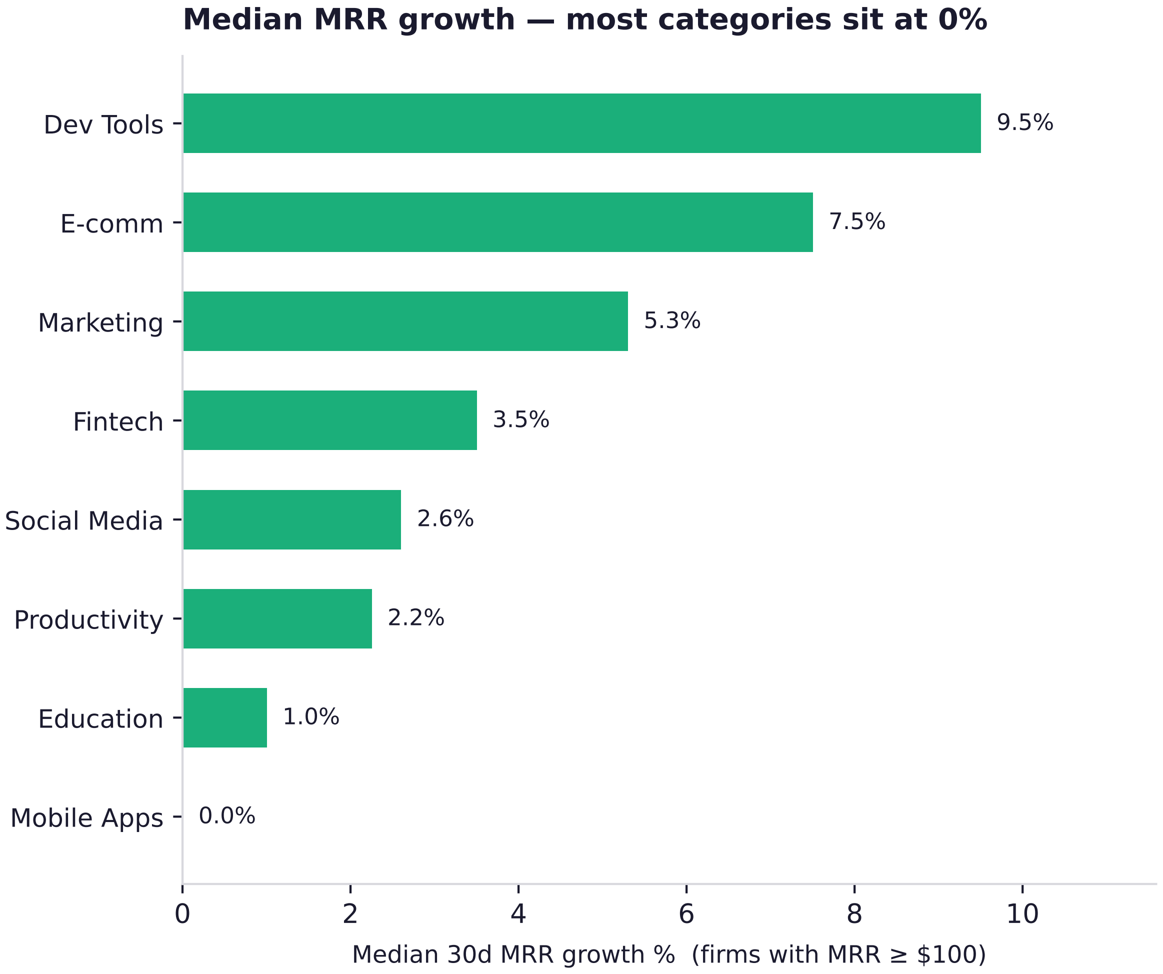


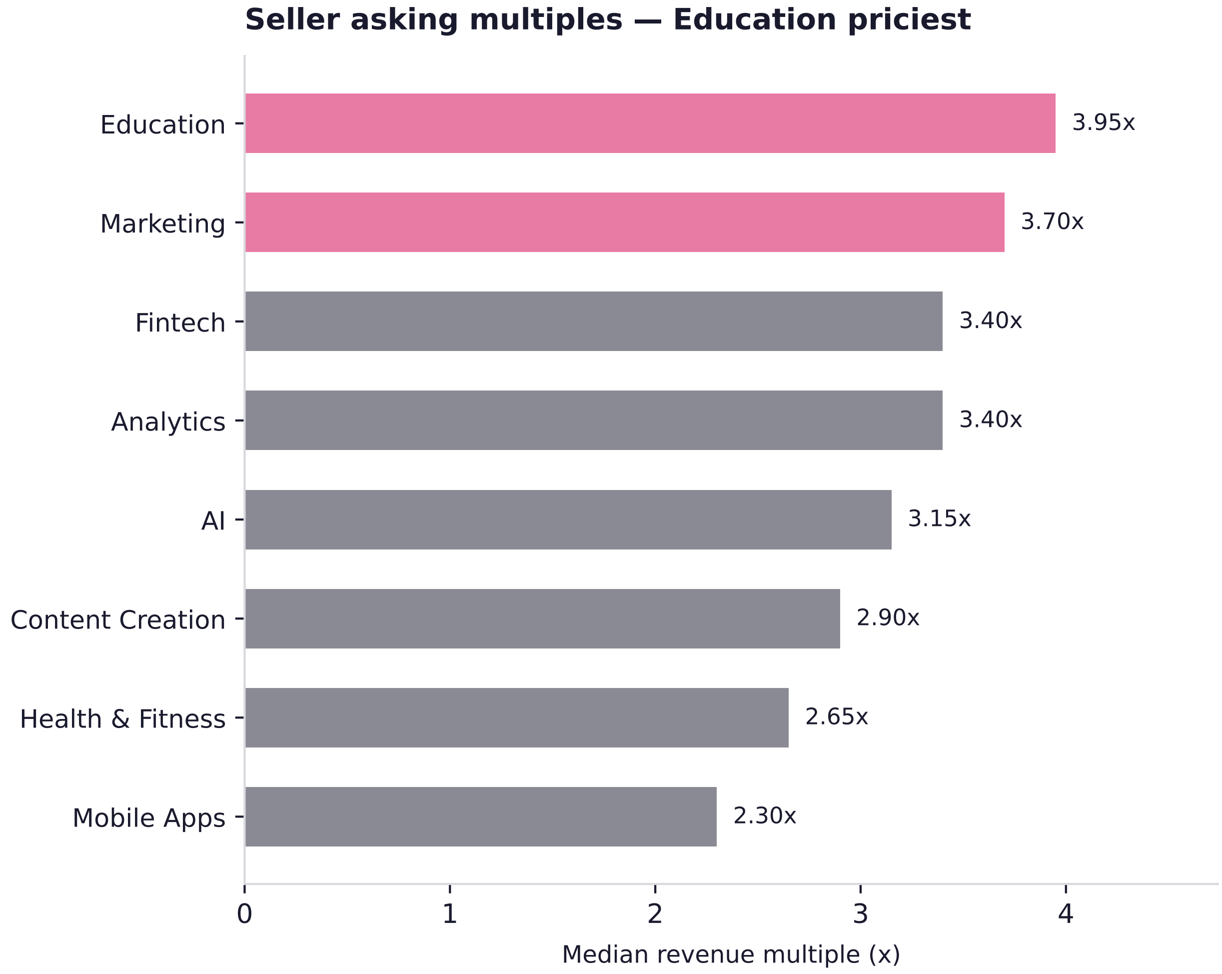


TAKEAWAY **AI leads on volume ($2.36M/30d) but 197 companies split it. E-comm ($58K) and Marketing ($31K) earn 5-10x more per company.**

TrustMRR 1,000-startup dataset · frozen 30 Jul 2026

Dev Tools is the only category where the median company is growing





TAKEAWAY **Dev Tools: +9.5% median growth, 68% of firms growing. Education sells at 3.95x but grows at 1% — price and momentum are inverted.**

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Every hub is an AI hub — differentiation lives in the second bet

Company count: country × category

	AI	SaaS	Dev Tools	Marketing	Mobile Apps	Productivity	Content Creation	Education	Health & Fitness
US	61	21	14	13	7	10	10	13	5
FR	20	10	1	4	4	1	5	1	1
IN	9	5	3	3	1	4		1	1
GB	16	4	1	1		3	1	2	3
CA	4	1		2	2	1	1	2	
DE	5	2		1	1	1	3	1	1
BR	2	2		1					3
HK	3	1	2	2			1		

Reading the map

US

Full stack: AI (61), SaaS (21), Dev Tools (14)

FR

Second AI hub (20) plus strong SaaS (10)

GB

AI-heavy (16) but thin everywhere else

IN

AI (9) and SaaS (5), mostly sub-scale MRR

BR

Only market with positive median growth (+1.8%)

TAKEAWAY **AI is table stakes everywhere. A country choice is really a choice of the second-strongest ecosystem around it.**

Buy in the US or India — 86 deals trade at 3x revenue or less

Where the sellers are (≥8 listings)

Country	Deals	Med ask	Med mult	Med MRR
US	72	$60K	2.5x	$1,810
GB	22	$30K	4.0x	$1,614
FR	18	$150K	3.3x	$4,753
IN	10	$6K	2.8x	$138
CA	8	$108K	5.8x	$2,132

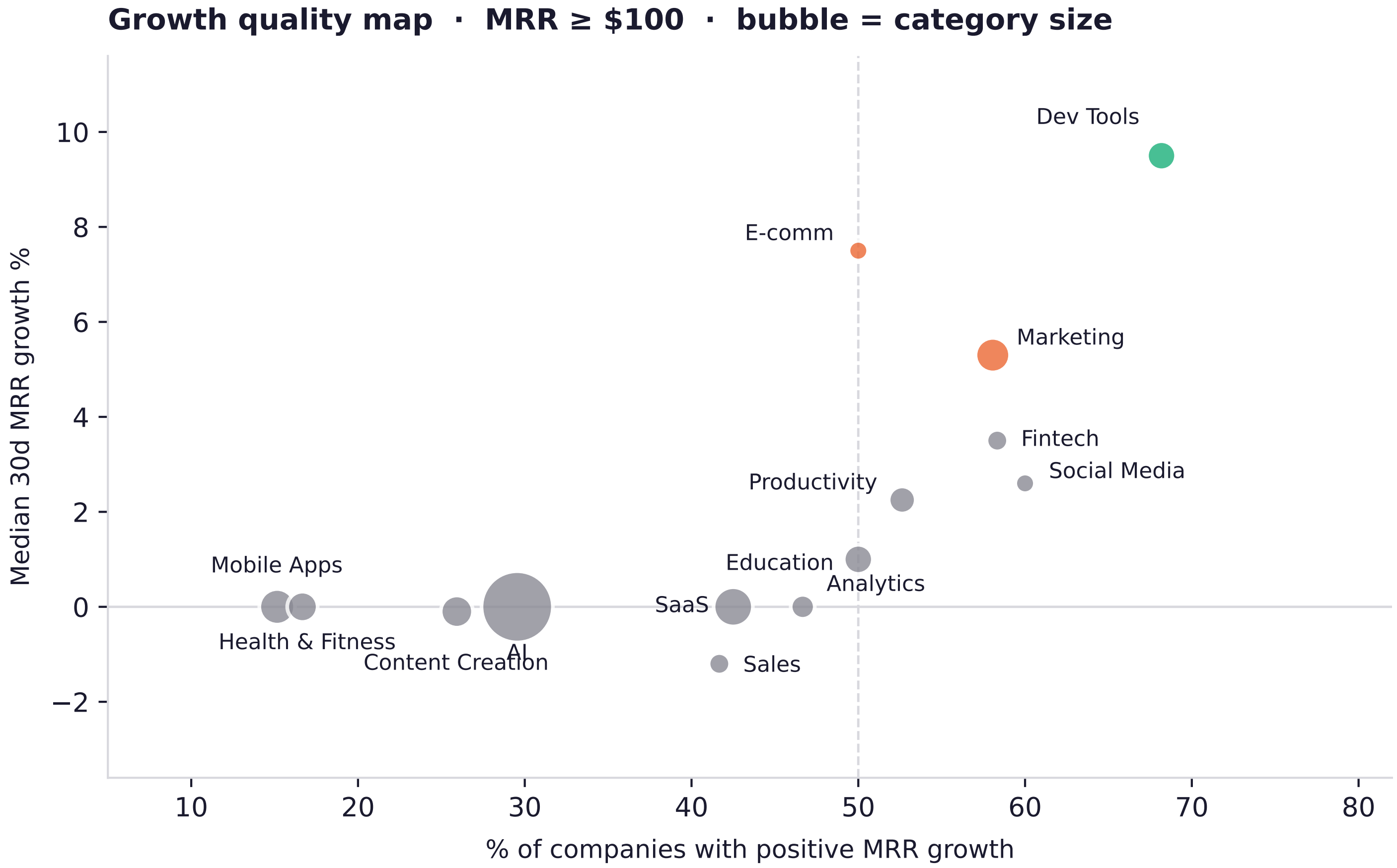
Value screen: MRR ≥ $500, multiple ≤ 3x — top 6 of 86

Target	Category	MRR	Ask	Mult
PolyPick	Fintech	$20,654	$23K	0.1x
Linkeddit	Sales	$1,036	$5K	0.2x
Aura For Creato...	AI	$1,800	$10K	0.5x
FishingAI	AI	$1,930	$30K	0.5x
InstaTrack	Mobile Apps	$3,204	$30K	0.5x
Leadbomb	SaaS	$3,633	$25K	0.6x

TAKEAWAY

India: $6.5K median ask, the cheapest entry. US: deepest pool at 72 deals, 2.55x, with real MRR. SaaS listed at 1.2x is the value pocket.

Build in Dev Tools — highest growth and broadest growth



If you're building

1. Dev Tools

+9.5% median · 68% growing · $1.3K med MRR

2. E-comm tools

+7.5% median · $15.6K med MRR, big tickets

3. Marketing

+5.3% median · 58% growing · $8.7K med MRR

Avoid: Mobile Apps

0% median growth · only 15% growing

Avoid: Health & Fitness

0% median growth · only 17% growing

TAKEAWAY **AI has 132 active firms but 0% median growth — crowded and flat. Dev Tools is smaller at 22 firms, but 2 in 3 are actively growing.**

US-Marketing is the single richest cell in the dataset

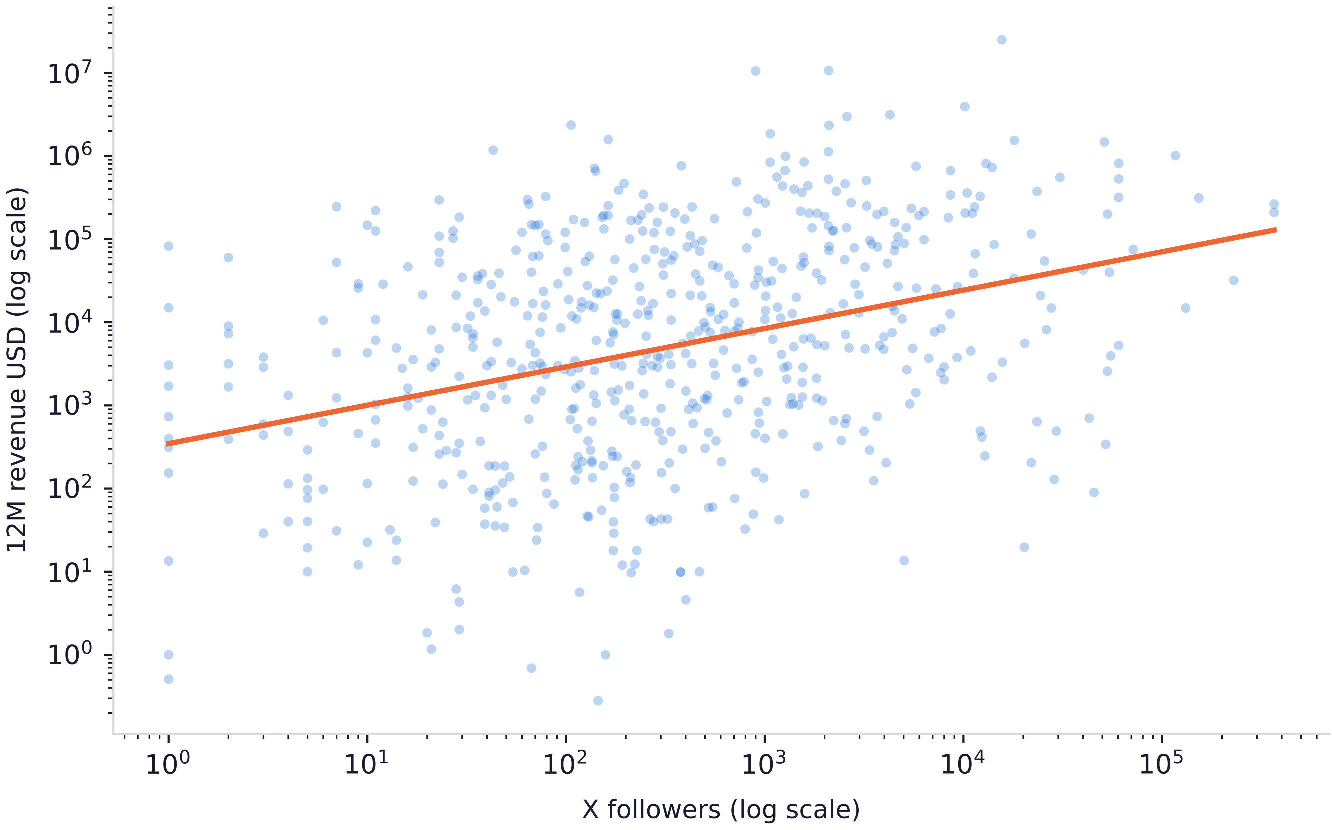
Country · Category	Firms	Median MRR	Median growth	Total 12M revenue
US · Marketing	13	$20,170	+8.1%	$12.30M
US · Analytics	5	$10,977	+0.0%	$2.67M
US · Education	13	$4,525	+5.5%	$5.03M
FR · Content Creation	5	$3,995	-0.3%	$0.46M
US · AI	61	$3,645	+0.0%	$13.26M
US · Health & Fitness	5	$2,235	+0.0%	$0.05M
US · Content Creation	10	$1,856	-2.4%	$0.65M
US · Sales	6	$1,850	-13.8%	$0.26M
US · SaaS	21	$1,772	+0.0%	$4.52M

TAKEAWAY

US-Marketing: $20.2K median MRR growing +8.1% a month, beating US-AI ($3.6K, flat). For AI outside the US, GB beats IN and DE on MRR.

X followers do not equal revenue — audience is a weak predictor

n = 607 companies with followers and revenue above zero



Correlation evidence

Pearson r (raw)

0.03 — essentially zero

Spearman rho (rank)

0.21 — weak

Pearson r (log-log)

0.36 — modest at best

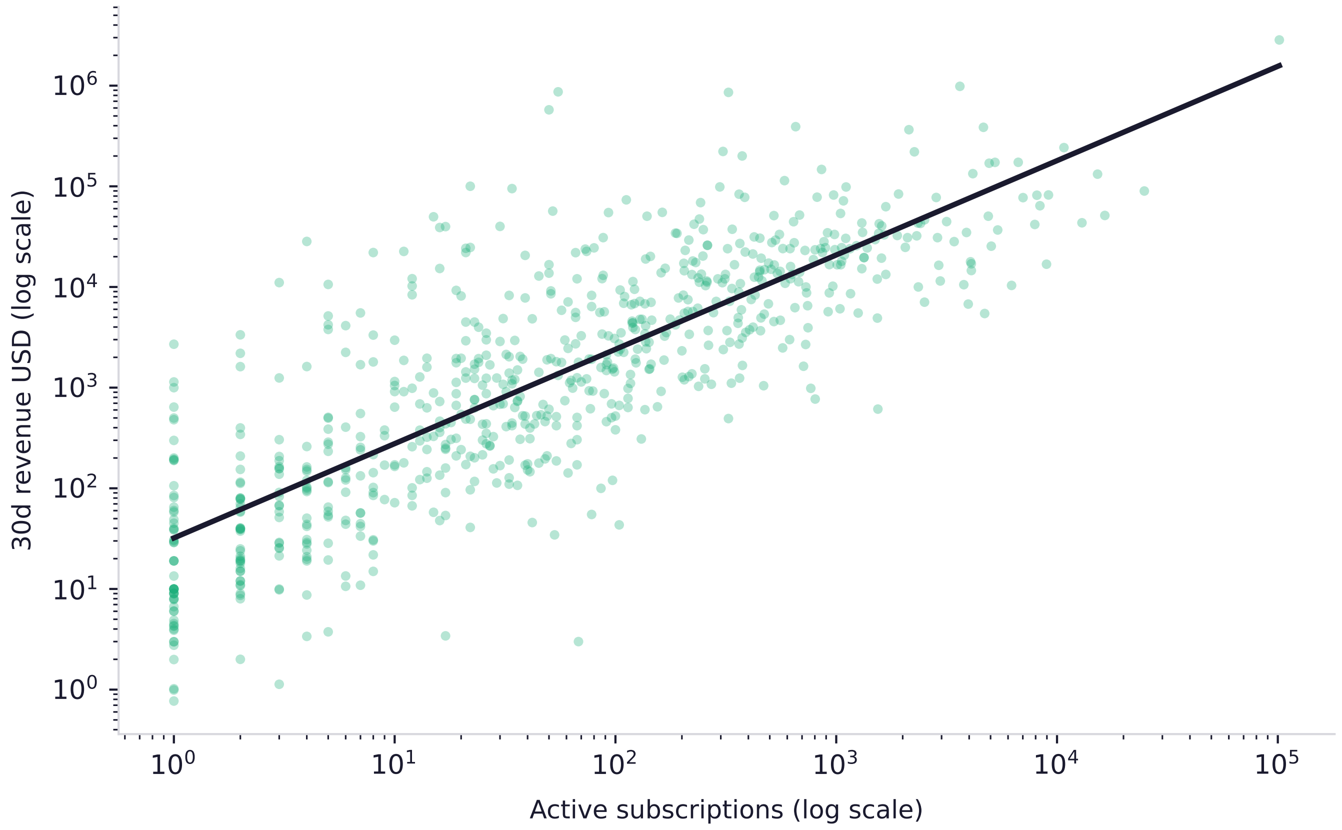
R-squared (log-log)

explains only ~13% of revenue variance

TAKEAWAY **87% of revenue variance is unexplained by follower count. Do not pay a premium for a target's audience — it barely converts.**

Subscriptions are the business: r = 0.80 with revenue

n = 736 · a tight power-law relationship



Correlation evidence

Pearson r

0.80 — strong

Spearman rho

0.82 — strong and monotonic

Pearson r (log-log)

0.81 — holds across every scale

Benchmark

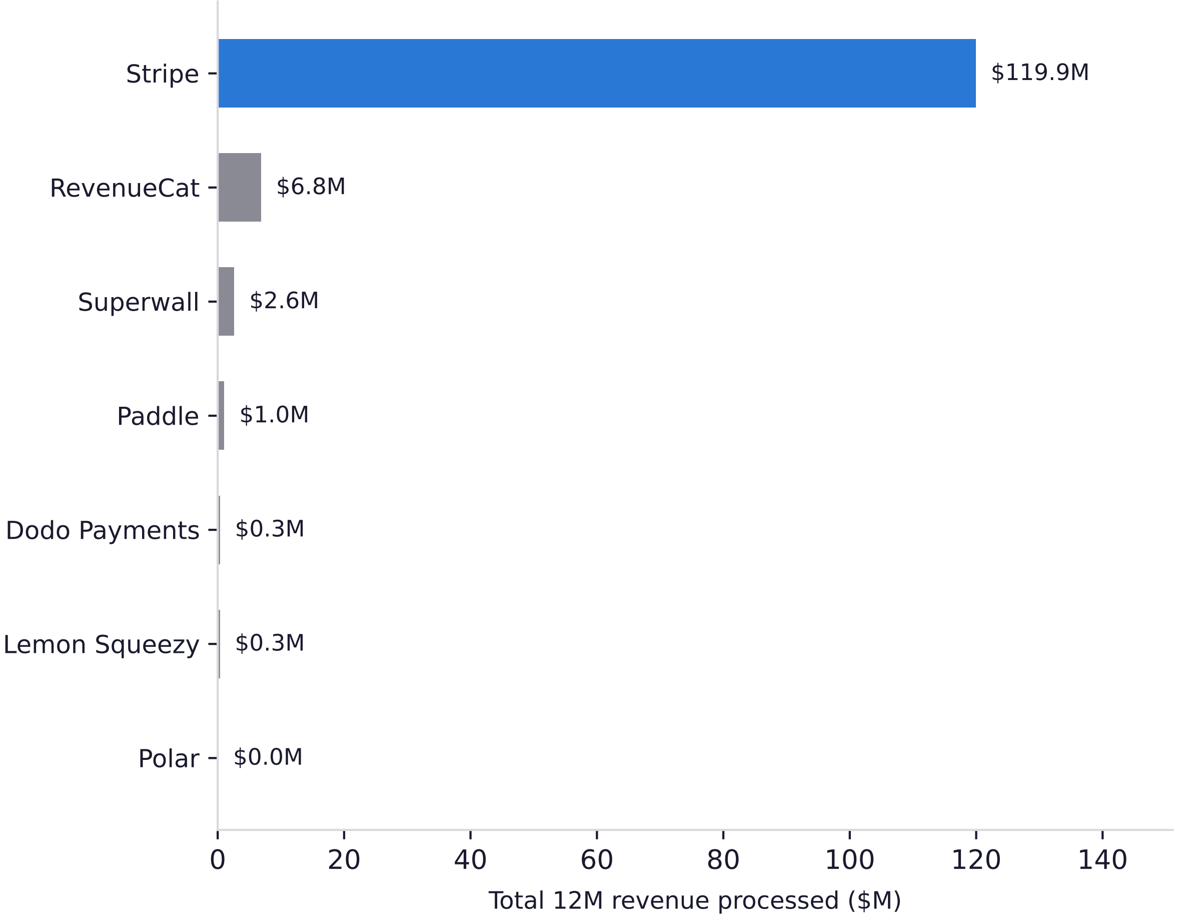
$20.07 per subscriber per month (Productivity)

TAKEAWAY **Diligence rule: value companies on subscribers x ARPU, not followers or traffic. Subs explain ~65% of revenue variance; followers ~13%.**

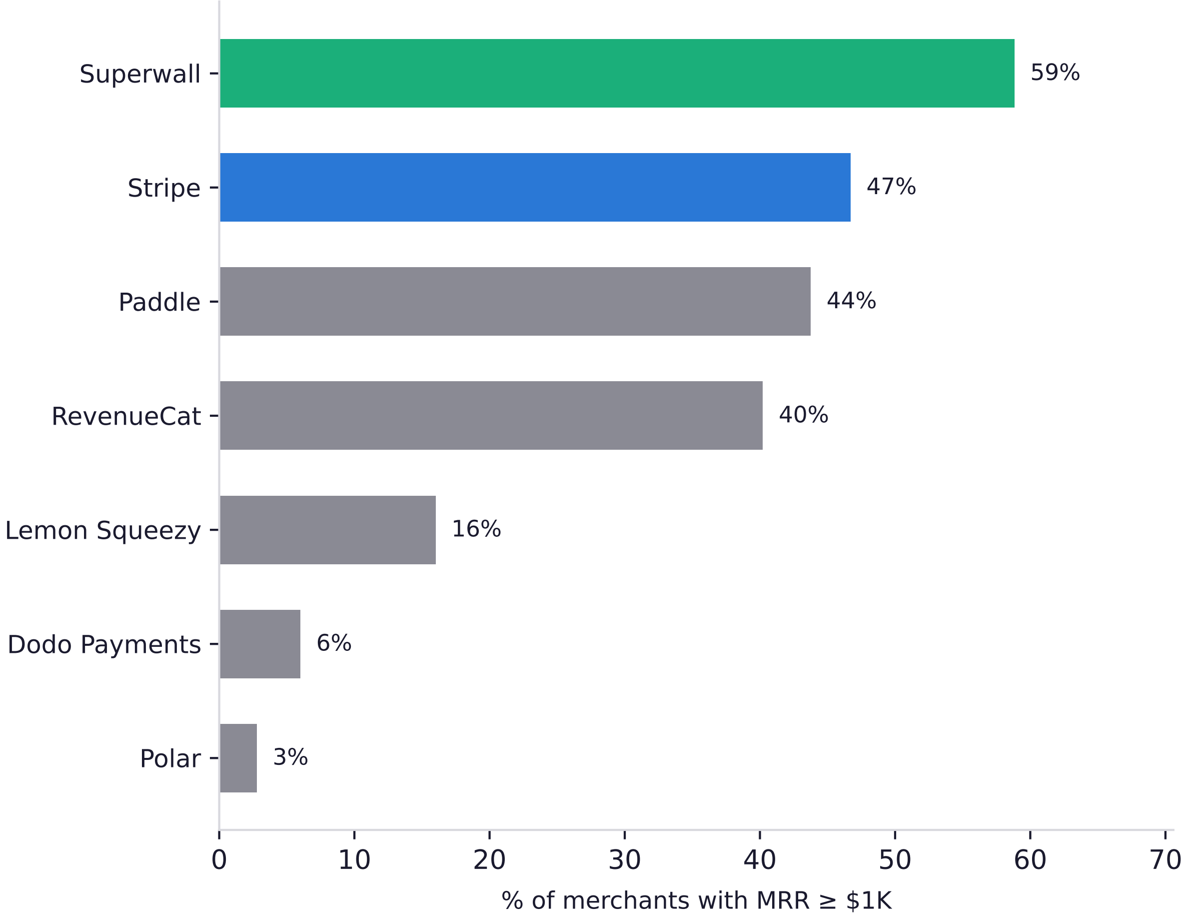
INSIGHT 9 · PAYMENT RAILS

Stripe processes 90% of the cash — Superwall hosts the best merchants

Cash volume by gateway



Merchant quality by gateway



TAKEAWAY

Stripe: $119.9M across 636 firms, the reliability default. Superwall: 59% of merchants earn $1K+ MRR. Polar and Dodo skew hobbyist, under 6%.

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SUMMARY

The decision card

IF YOU'RE BUYING

- US SaaS at a 1.2x median multiple is the value pocket
- India is the cheapest entry, $6.5K median ask
- Screen: MRR over $500 and multiple under 3x gives 86 live deals
- Pay for subscribers (r=0.80), never for followers (r=0.03)

IF YOU'RE BUILDING

- Dev Tools: +9.5% median growth, 68% of firms growing
- E-comm tools: fewer players, $15.6K median MRR
- Skip Mobile Apps and Health: 0% growth, under 17% growing
- AI is crowded: 197 firms and flat median growth

OPERATING CHOICES

- Stripe for reliability: $119.9M processed across 636 firms
- Superwall cohort holds the highest-quality merchants
- Benchmark ARPU: about $20 per subscriber per month
- Best cell to sell into: US-Marketing, $20K MRR at +8.1%

Caveats

Revenue multiples are available for only 26% of on-sale rows. Growth medians include many verified-but-plateaued firms sitting at 0%. The dataset is TrustMRR-listed and carries an indie-hacker skew, so it is not representative of the whole market.